

The Reality of Building

What 1,000 verified startups tell us about where the money actually is

58% of them earn less than \$1,000 a month.

THE ASK Build a course that takes founders from \$1k to \$10k a month — because building is now a commodity, and scaling is the bottleneck.

TrustMRR: revenue you cannot fake

Founders connect a read-only payment key. Numbers are pulled from the processor, not typed in.

01

Connect

Read-only API key from Stripe,
RevenueCat, Polar, Paddle, Lemon
Squeezy

02

Verify

Revenue synced automatically — no
screenshots, no self-reporting

03

Publish

Public profile, live revenue badge,
dofollow backlink (DR 68)

04

Monetise

Free listings → paid ads →
acquisition marketplace

Where the money comes from in our sample

Stripe 636 listings · 87% of all revenue

RevenueCat + Superwall 206 listings · the mobile-app
economy

5 others 158 listings · <2% of revenue

INSIGHT FOR PRAXEL Verified data is a trust product. Praxel's equivalent is verified capability — portfolios and outputs, not certificates.

Not used: 8 individual provider names collapsed into 3 groups — five providers hold under 2% of revenue between them and add no decision value.

Marc Lou

French indie hacker · solo founder · no VC · @marc_louvion

Oct 2025

Pieter Levels posts about fake MRR screenshots. Millions of views.

+48 hours

Marc ships TrustMRR. A weekend build, not a funded roadmap.

Week one

35,000 visitors. \$18K MRR of ad slots sold out.

By 2026

The default credibility layer for indie startups — and a marketplace.

What he actually did

He did not build a better product.

He found a public argument, shipped the resolution in a weekend, and owned the category before anyone else finished discussing it.

Speed was the moat.

INSIGHT FOR PRAXEL This is the exact arc 'Prompt to Production' promises. Marc Lou is the case study — and a mentor worth pursuing.

■ THE DATASET

1,000 startups, verified to the cent

1,000

startups
29 columns

65

countries
represented

\$15.6M

revenue in the
last 30 days

\$334M

earned across
all time

500,597

active paid
subscriptions

54%

have existed for less than a year

\$3,620

is the median lifetime revenue

590

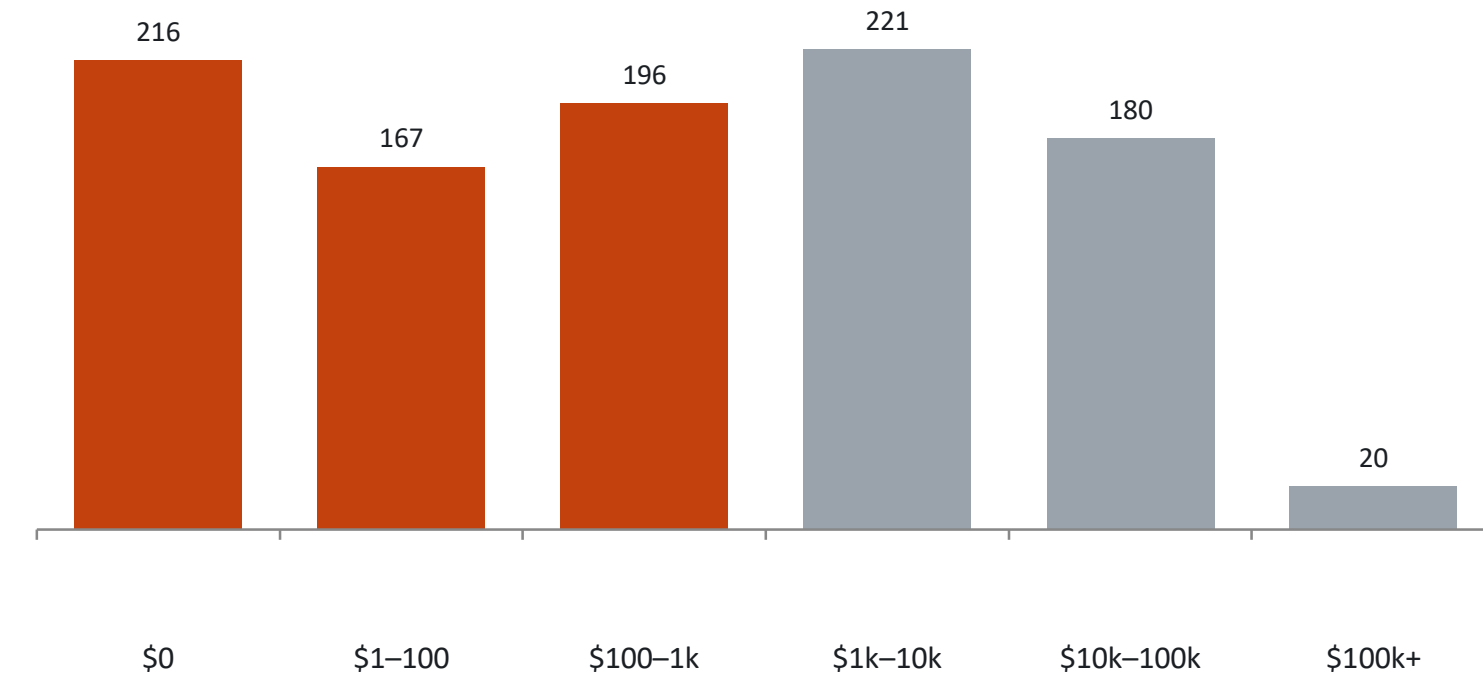
have earned under \$10,000 — ever

Read it as a census of the early-stage AI builder — not a list of successful companies.

INSIGHT FOR PRAXEL Praxel's learner is not pre-startup. They are already shipping — and stuck under \$10k lifetime. That is a monetisation problem, not a building one.

Limitations carried throughout: self-selected sample (only founders willing to expose a payment key), a single frozen snapshot with no time series, and 216 rows where \$0 is used in place of a null.

Almost everyone is earning almost nothing



30-day revenue band, number of startups

579

startups — 58% — earn under \$1,000 a month.

Median: \$400

Mean: \$15,596

A 39x gap. Every average you have ever read about this market was wrong.

INSIGHT FOR PRAXEL Sell the outcome learners actually lack: first paying customers. 'Build an app' is a solved problem — \$1k MRR is not.

Eleven startups own half the money

11

startups out of 1,000 account for 50% of all revenue in the dataset.

Top 1	18.2%
Top 10	49.6%
Top 100	83.7%
Bottom 500	0.2%

share of total 30-day revenue

Who they are

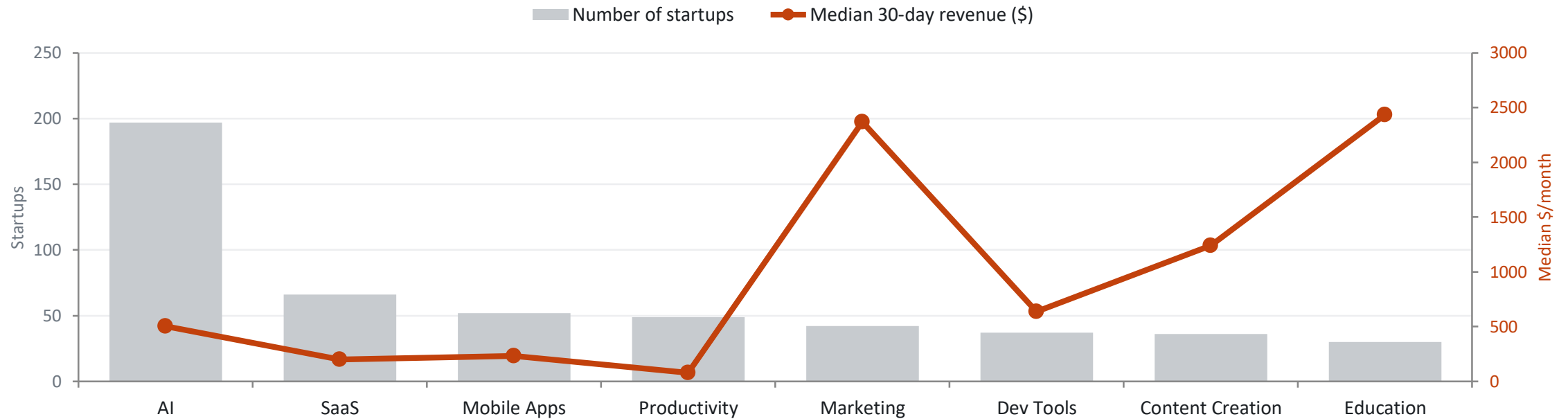
Stan	\$2.84M
Brand On Demand	\$985k
Stack Influence	\$868k
Comp AI	\$575k
1Lookup	\$391k

All five are US-based. Four sell to businesses.

INSIGHT FOR PRAXEL Do not teach to the outliers. Praxel's cohort will live in the long tail — design the curriculum for the \$0 to \$10k journey.

Not used: revenue growth rates on this slide. At these revenue levels a 3,000% jump is \$10 becoming \$310 — the percentage misleads.

The most crowded category is not the best paid



AI has 4x the companies of SaaS and a median 5x below Education.

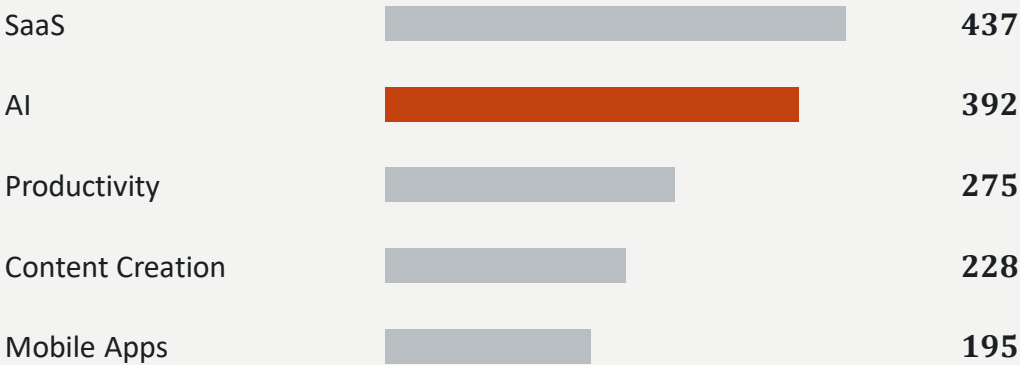
Productivity is the worst bet on the board: 49 startups, \$80 a month.

INSIGHT FOR PRAXEL Point cohorts at Education, Marketing and Content Creation — proven demand, a tenth of the competition, and adjacent to what Praxel already teaches.

Two corrections to how founders position

AI is a layer, not a market

197 startups call AI their category.
392 use it as a tag on something else.



Everyone builds B2C. B2B pays.

	B2B	B2C
Startups	255	401
Median revenue	\$1,240	\$304
Revenue per customer	\$49.00	\$9.30
4x the revenue. 5x per customer. 1.6x fewer people trying.		

INSIGHT FOR PRAXEL Reframe the workshops: not 'build an AI product' but 'apply AI to a business that already pays'. B2B-first, vertical-first.

Not used: the 'Both' audience segment (56 startups). Too small to separate and it blurs the B2B/B2C contrast that drives the decision.

India ships in volume and earns almost nothing

Country	Startups	Median \$/month
United States	258	\$1,396
France	79	\$629
India	59	\$24
United Kingdom	50	\$128
Canada	29	\$1,222

58x

The gap between the median Indian and American startup on this list.

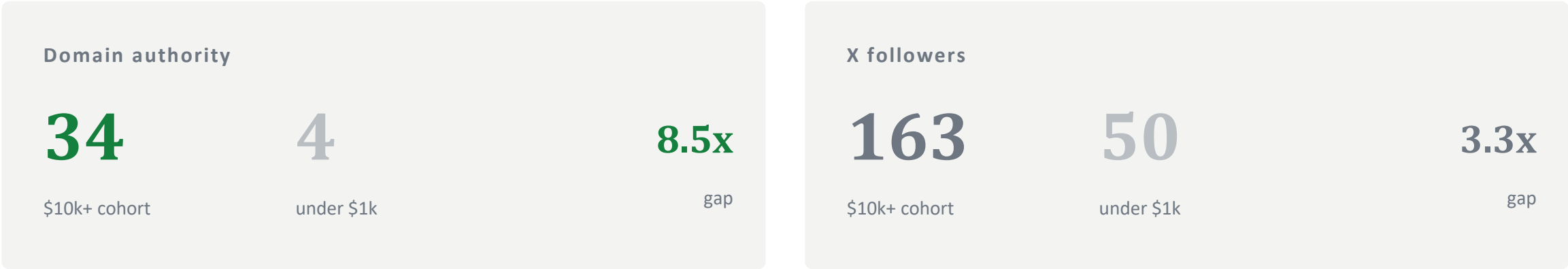
39% of Indian listings earn zero.
5.9% of the startups.
0.9% of the money.

INSIGHT FOR PRAXEL This gap is Praxel's entire market, quantified. Indian builders have shipping ability and no monetisation ability — that is a curriculum, not a coincidence.

Not used: 52 countries with under 10 listings, and 241 rows with no country. Both are too thin to compare fairly.

Distribution beats audience

Comparing startups earning \$10k+/month against those under \$1k/month:



The domain a founder chooses says more than the followers they have

.ai	.io	.com	.app
\$1,914	\$1,004	\$204	\$102

31% of these founders have zero followers on X. Only 5.7% have more than 10,000.
Audience is not the bottleneck. Being findable is.

INSIGHT FOR PRAXEL Add distribution to the core curriculum — SEO, domains, launch surfaces. Praxel currently teaches building; the data says the gap is being found.

Correlation is weak (0.33 for domain authority, 0.18 for followers) — read this as a pattern worth teaching, not a formula that guarantees revenue.

One in four listings is quietly for sale

262

startups listed
for acquisition

\$35,000

median asking
price

2.3x

median multiple
of revenue

37%

priced under
\$10,000

What this makes possible

A working business with real customers and verified revenue can be bought for the price of a laptop and a holiday.

For-sale listings earn 3x the dataset median (\$879 vs \$278) — these are functioning assets, not abandoned projects.

What is being sold

AI		54
Mobile Apps		29
SaaS		22
Content Creation		11

INSIGHT FOR PRAXEL A fourth pillar for 'Excel': buy, don't build. No existing Indian programme teaches micro-acquisition — and the founders can act on it personally.

Not used: asking prices above \$1M (21 listings) in the median. Multiples run to 326x with no diligence behind them — unreliable at the top end.

Six moves this data supports

01 Teach monetisation, not building

58% are stuck under \$1k/month

02 Make every cohort B2B-first

\$1,240 vs \$304 median revenue

03 Position AI as a layer on a vertical

AI category median \$503 vs Education \$2,435

04 Add distribution as a core module

Domain authority 34 vs 4 across cohorts

05 Launch 'buy, don't build' under Excel

262 listings, 37% under \$10,000

06 Recruit mentors from the \$10k+ band

180 verified operators, publicly reachable

Praxel does not need a new thesis. It needs to point an existing one at the gap this data just measured.